flow of ideas; in others, you have to hold a tight leash to prevent the discussion going off track. But one norm that almost always helped was to maintain discipline about the start and end times of a meeting. Rakesh Mohan, who evidently was aware of this time-discipline syndrome of mine, advised me before my first TAC meeting that I relax my tight leash and allow these meetings to be open-ended and free-flowing. I followed Rakesh's advice and benefitted immensely from doing so.

The TAC meetings would typically run for four to five hours, and on occasion even longer. There is an extensive presentation by the Reserve Bank staff of their analysis which is freely interspersed by several interventions, clarifications and comments by the members. After the presentation and discussion, and several rounds of samosas, pastries and tea giving ample food for thought, each external member would be invited to give his or her perspective on the macroeconomic situation, estimates for growth and inflation, and specific advice on the policy parameters.

The evolved best practice in central banks has been to release the minutes of their monetary policy committee meetings after a gap of three to four weeks. This transparency is aimed at guiding market participants on the different points of view and nuances that informed the final decision of the committee. Although the TAC is strictly not a monetary policy committee, we decided, in consultation with the external members, to adopt the global best practice, and in 2011, began the practice of putting out the minutes of the TAC meeting in the public domain four weeks after the meeting date. The recommendations of the members would be recorded in the minutes without attribution so that the market could get a sense of the TAC advice that informed the governor's decision.

More often than not, I differed with the advice of the TAC, especially during the tightening cycle when the TAC typically advised a softer approach relative to my final decision. Quite unsurprisingly, the media would play this up with catchy headlines like 'Subbarao differs again with his advisers', or 'Governor overrules his committee'. Even if there was a bit of sensationalism in the headlines, I welcomed this publicity since